

WHIDBEY ISLAND HORSE COUNCIL
MEETING MINUTES
AUGUST 13, 2025

The meeting was called to order at 6:00 by coordinator Sally Garratt. Present were Betsy, Leslie, Connie, Bruce, Karena, Brigit (joined later) and Sally. Minutes of the last meeting were reviewed and approved.

Leslie reported on her communications with Island County regarding keeping the interests of the equine community at the forefront of county planning. She said that the comp plan already covered some of our concerns but that the Plan should include more specific horse interests. Leslie will attempt to keep equine interests at the forefront of county awareness by attending county commissioners meetings and will listen in to the meetings of the Planning Commission. She will also meet in person with Commissioner Melanie Bacon to express our concerns.

Rhed was not present so we did not get an update on the equine resource directory that she is working on or on her youth projects. Connie said that she will contact Rhed and volunteer to help on the compilation of the Equine resource directory.

Leslie will review other "horse council" mission statements and propose one for the Whidbey Island Horse Council.

Betsy volunteered to look into communications of horse related issues on the Island through Facebook and other social media means including posting on the Whidbey Island Equine Network.

The announced sale of Bell's Farm, a 85 acre former strawberry farm in Central Whidbey was discussed. The farm is protected by a conservation easement but 17 acres are available for development. The possibility of purchasing the farm for an equestrian center was considered and explored. The sale price is approximately 2.6m.

The Council discussed updating the economic impact survey of equines on Whidbey Island done by the Island County Conservation District in 2015. We acknowledged that the survey is out of date and that many more equines are present on the island now than responded to the survey in 2015. An updated survey could influence planning decisions by the county and could influence decisions made by the Land Trust and other land owners regarding use of land for equine activities. Leslie will discuss this issue with Commissioner Bacon at their meeting. Connie will discuss engaging the Conservation District in an update with Jerry (who has some dealings with the Conservation District).

The meeting was adjourned at 8p. Bruce suggested starting the meeting a half hour later to help with afterwork schedules.

The next meeting will be held on September 10 at 6:30pm (NEW TIME) at the Race Road Firehouse.